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Rhetorical Theory and Professional Writing

In the passage, James E. Porter explains the concept of a theory within the domain of technical writing, eventually providing a theory to be utilized within the process of technical authorship. He presents an array of definitions for the term “theory,” choosing the idea that a theory is “a conceptual framework . . . that provides . . . a way of looking at the world” (128). Porter demonstrates that a theory can be used as a heuristic to analyze and better understand technical communication. Porter explains that a theory determines the manner in which a technical communicator views both their subject matter and their eventual output. Whether they are attempting to create a website documenting a particular business practice or developing a content management system for an entire organization, a theory should guide the author throughout the entire process.

After establishing the conceptual framework of *theory-as-a-heuristic*, Porter presents a rhetorical heuristic designed to enhance an author’s understanding of the system they are working within. Essentially, authors should turn their attention to the overall process “that users are engaged in” (140) and design their final product to fit within the needs of the users. A proficient piece of technical documentation adapts to its audience, dynamically shifting mediums where necessary, and is written by an author that has a deep understanding of their users. To ensure such an output, Porter demonstrates throughout the passage how rhetorical theories can be utilized to develop such an intricate perception of both the technical needs of a system and the audience that will use it.

Porter methodically develops his central advice within the passage, eventually espousing the following theme: in technical writing, the author should focus on the system

they are working within, instead of only attempting to convey their desired content. Such a practical approach to authorship resonates with my particular ideals, which favor philosophies that encourage a broad understanding of dynamic systems. When communicating or evaluating a topic, I personally attempt to understand both the individual subject and the system that it resides in. In my view, an understanding is not complete without being extended to a subject's surroundings. There are a great many manners in which one can approach technical authorship, some of which will result in similar outcomes to the theories outlined by Porter, but I agree with the technique that an author should begin by attempting to understand their environment. Porter's use of the term *theory* resonates with my evaluation in this domain. He takes great lengths to properly define the term, landing on theory as "the fundamental and necessary principles guiding [. . .] work as a technical communicator" (130). All systems require a mental model, or a theory, to be constructed in order to develop a proper understanding. This reality extends to both technical subject matter and the communication required to convey it. Porter illustrates this relationship throughout the passage, and I agree with the argument built around that central premise.

Works Cited

- Porter, James E. "How Can Rhetoric Theory Inform the Practice of Technical Communication?" *Solving Problems in Technical Communication*, edited by Johndan Johnson-Eilola and Stuart A. Selber, University of Chicago Press, 2013, pp. 125–41.